

Cause for concern: Dehydration loomed large and players battled exhaustion under the blazing sun.

BETWEEN ITS FIRST-EVER TEST AGAINST THE WEST INDIES IN 1976 AND ITS LATEST INTERNATIONAL RED-BALL FIXTURE AGAINST AUSTRALIA IN DECEMBER 2023, INDIA HAS PLAYED 40 TESTS, WINNING SEVEN, LOSING SIX, AND DRAWING 27

"It's something we're looking to do here. Academies are starting to play two- or three-day cricket. It's unbelievable that the girls go into international Test fixtures with just a handful of multi-day games under their belt, if any at all. Compare this to the guys who have at least 30-40 red ball games to their names before they play the format internationally. That is something we're determined to address. We know, at the Southern Vipers, that this is something we want to do. But something more concrete, like a tournament, is yet to take shape," she adds.

England, a nation enamoured (or blindsided, depending on where you stand) by the men's team's 'Bazball' philosophy, has a women's set-up

where the playing style has been brisk. Where the women's side struggles is in taking control of the game and slowing things down. It helped India eke out a draw in 2021 and thrash the same opponent by 347 runs a few months ago.

"England seems to have a decent approach to how they want to go about their T20 cricket. They want to be a bit more aggressive, and that helps their mindset. The mindset issue comes in Test cricket when you have to bat longer, and so a strong defence comes into the scheme of things. That might not be how they

want to play their cricket, but that might be what is required as you then earn the right to bat. India did that brilliantly. India scored at over four runs an over throughout the innings. They were able to absorb pressure well thanks to a strong defence. Whenever an opportunity presented itself, they were able to dispatch the loose balls. I think that was a great blueprint on how to bat in Test cricket," Edwards points out.

"The fact that there were so many bowled dismissals is a cause for concern, and I guess that's where the strong defence comes into play. It was quite disappointing on that front to see us being completely outplayed, especially with the kind of batting we have."

Necessity or luxury

Sthalekar remembers a time when former Australia Women's head coach Matthew Mott (now with the England men's white-ball side)

brushed aside the need for red-ball experience.

"I remember asking Matthew Mott this question while doing commentary.

"My thought was that if you play the longer format, you get a better understanding of your skillset and how to pace your innings. He believed that a longer format doesn't necessarily create great players. David Warner is a prime example of this — a T20 player who entered the Test arena. It's not one-size-fits-all. My opinion is that red-ball cricket has developmental value," she says.

"The fact that the BCCI has put on this tournament is encouraging foresight. They saw that the last two Tests against England and Australia ended triumphantly. They realise that this is a format that brings them great success, especially on home soil.

"This bodes well for those who want to play more Test cricket because they'll be able to produce some wonderful players. This tournament showed that there were several players who put their hands up whom you don't otherwise see on the circuit," she adds.

Shubhangi is quick to point out that a mere Inter-Zonal is not the start and end of work.

"In terms of skill development and technique, the longer version will certainly help. But it will be a challenge. Right now, the Inter-Zonal is a good format. Quality players who can adapt to the shorter versions and double up for red ball were in the mix.

"If we look at the inter-state level, we need to see if that is viable and if they have the resources to allow the format to trickle down to the grass-roots club/district level. It is going to be a challenge for all countries, including us," she says.

As things stand, the sole red-ball fixture on the international calendar is the Women's Ashes Pink Ball game at the MCG in 2025.

The debate persists: Should more international Tests drive domestic multi-day cricket, or should red-ball cricket be introduced independently? Time will decide.